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Things are slightly different in the IT arena, more specifically as a PC user. Switch to Linux, and you are part of an exclusive club that only grants membership to one in a 100 PC users. But, if 1 per cent is still too crowded for you, get BSD. With a 0.01 per cent market share of PC users (1 in 10,000), switching to BSD is as close as you can get to running your system on a custom OS.

Requirements

System devices

Since hardware manufacturers are not too enthusiastic to release non-Windows drivers of their products, the availability of BSD drivers of the latest hardware is not guaranteed. To be on the safe side, it is best to get a distro with a release date later than the purchase date of the hardware, on which it will be installed. And having a system built with components of popular brands such as Intel, Realtek

and Creative goes a long way in facilitating the search for drivers. FreeBSD is accompanied by a hardware compatibility list, which can be perused to be certain of success, or as is usual we can visit it if the installation fails!

FreeBSD takes up about 1 GB of space to install a basic GUI version. Depending on the packages you intend to install, you need to allocate more space. 5 GB space should be adequate for installing the OS with either of the main bundled window managers – KDE or Gnome. Those not acquainted with either window manager can install both, after reserving about 10 GB of disk space.

Preparing the hard disk

If your hard disk already has unpartitioned disk space or an existing partition can be deleted, the in-built partition editor is all that is needed. But, unlike the disk managers that are available with Linux distros, the FB partition editor cannot resize existing partitions. The process of freeing up disk space is complicated due to this. The best solution is

to get a Linux live CD and use the resizing tool to squeeze existing partitions to free about 5 GB of space. Of course, any partition modification process is risky, and it is best to make a backup of your data to cover any eventuality.

FB uses the term “Slice” to denote disk area. In a Slice, partitions are carved out to allocate space for different files. In common parlance, a Slice would be equivalent to an extended partition, with logical partitions within it. FB recommends a root / partition to store core OS files, a /usr partition to store user files (including programs etc) and a /swap partition for temporary storage.

Installation

FB is available as a DVD or as a pack of 5 CDs. To start off installation, pop in the bootable CD1 into the optical drive, and modify the boot order in the BIOS and restart the PC. FB boots up and presents a boot menu to choose the mode of boot. For most users, the normal boot should be selected. If the

Getting High on BSD

